

TO SERVE AND PROTECT

Software to keep your PC in tip-top condition, protect it from intrusion and recover lost data

Like it or not, the computer has become an integral part of our daily lives. We depend on it to perform mission-critical tasks, we turn to it for keeping in touch with our friends and family, we use it for entertainment and for storing records and appointments. Then when we need it the most, it gets infected by viruses, or attacked by hackers and Trojans, and promptly crashes. Time and again, the PC has demonstrated that it is not to be taken for granted. Even while working with simple Word and Excel documents, you had better be quick on that [Ctrl] + [S] draw or be ready to lose your work. These inevitabilities are etched in stone and will invariably cause frequent loss of data or hair, maybe both.

But a solution is right around the corner, which will go a long way in preventing problems and reducing the post-catastrophe heartache. The solution is in the form of a system suite—a collection of tools and utilities that keep a tab on the health of your computer, protecting it from viruses and attacks, even as they help maintain and recover critical data and important files. We have evaluated three such suites: McAfee Utilities, Norton SystemWorks 2002 and Ontrack SystemSuite 4.0 to help you decide on the best one to count on.

How they fared

We identified three distinct scenarios under which one might run a system suite: to enable system security, for system maintenance and for the purpose of a system recovery. We based our analysis of a particular suite on its performance under the three usage groups. The first case, security, is offered via anti-virus and

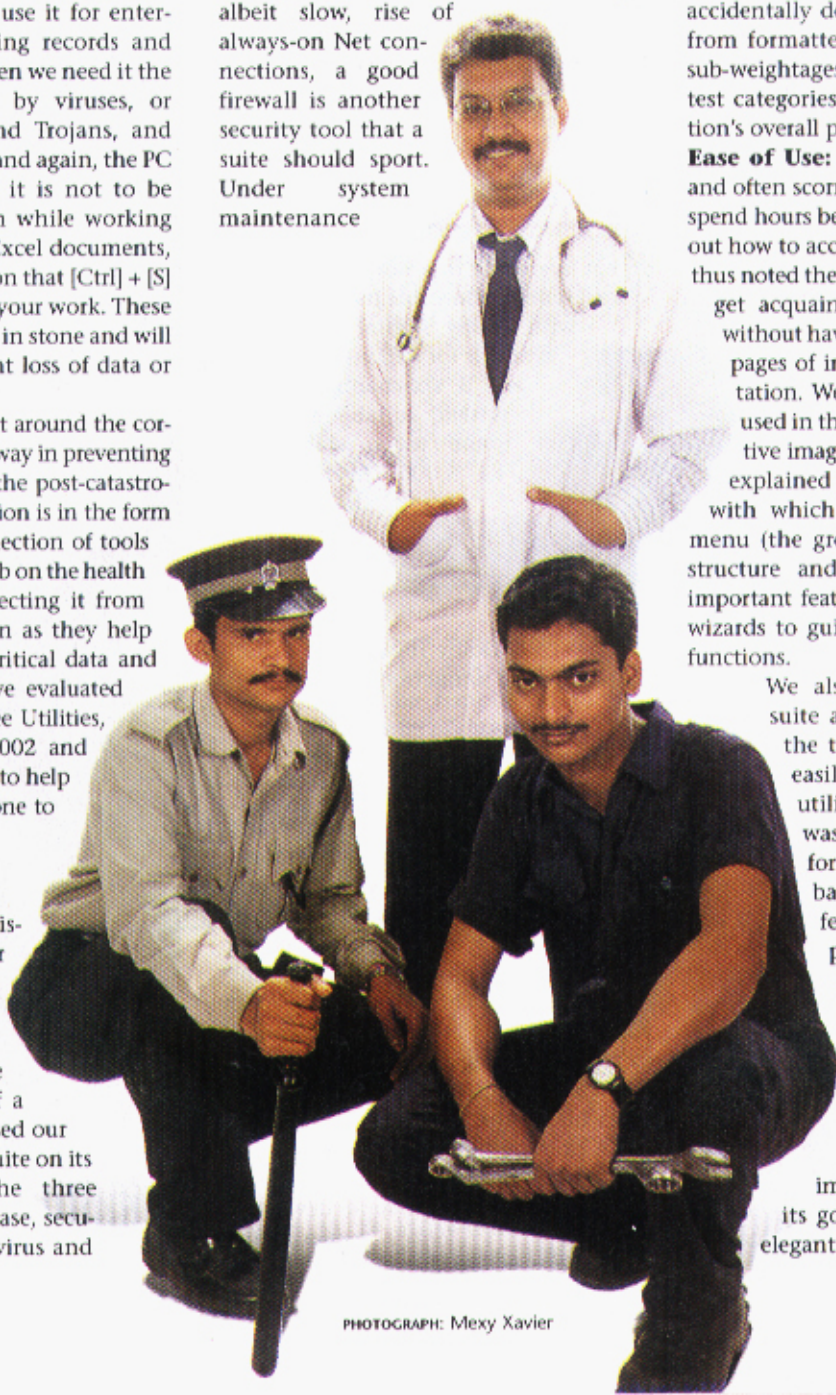
firewall tools. The presence of a robust anti-virus software is arguably one of the most important inclusions in a system suite. Thanks to the ever-increasing popularity of the Internet and the steady, albeit slow, rise of always-on Net connections, a good firewall is another security tool that a suite should sport. Under system maintenance

fall utilities that defragment your hard disk and scan it for errors. Registry cleaners and data backup tools are also included here. Finally, system recovery tools are those that prevent system crashes, restore accidentally deleted files as well as data from formatted hard disks. There were sub-weightages accorded to each of these test categories to ascertain the application's overall performance.

Ease of Use: Manuals are seldom read and often scorned upon. A user need not spend hours bent over a manual to figure out how to accomplish a certain task. We thus noted the ease with which a user can get acquainted with a system suite without having to pore over pages and pages of instructions and documentation. We noted whether the icons used in the applications had descriptive imagery or popup tool-tips that explained their function; the ease with which you could navigate the menu (the grouping of features, menu structure and intuitive placement of important features); and the presence of wizards to guide you through different functions.

We also checked whether the suite allowed you to customise the toolbar so that you could easily access frequently used utilities. Ontrack SystemSuite was the only one that allowed for customisation of the toolbar. Ironically though, this feature is very awkwardly placed within the interface (inside the SizeManager under Optimize and Maintain). Thankfully, you will have to hunt for this feature only once in the beginning.

The Ontrack suite impressed us the most with its good-looking interface and elegant menu structure, making it



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